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AUSTRALIA MOURNS SHOOTING VICTIMS

A man gestures as he lays flowers at a tribute for shooting victims outside the Bondi Pavilion at Sydney's Bondi Beach yesterday. A 10-year-old girl, a Holocaust survivor and a local rabbi were among 15 people killed, while 42 others were rushed to hospital with gunshot wounds and other injuries after a father and son fired into crowds packing the Sydney beach for the start of Hanukkah on Sunday evening.

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World's longest flight takes off

19,956km from Shanghai to Buenos Aires covered in 29 hours

DUBAI
BY DHANUSHA GOKULAN
Chief Reporter

A new record for the world's longest commercial flight route has been set by China Eastern Airlines, which has launched a 29-hour journey linking Shanghai and Buenos Aires, according to international media reports.

The 316-seat Boeing 777-300ER flight covers around 12,400 miles (19,956km), roughly half the circumference of the globe, making it the longest commercial airline route currently in operation. According to *The Independent*, the inaugural service left Shanghai at 2am local time on December 4. It arrived in Buenos Aires at 4.45pm local time, touching down 10



minutes ahead of schedule. The airline describes the route as a significant new connection between Asia and South America.

The flight is operated with a stop in Auckland, New Zealand, where the aircraft is refuelled, and crews are rotated, according to reports. Because of this layover, the service does not qualify as the world's longest non-stop or "direct" flight, but its total duration still makes it the longest commercial route door-to-door.

By overall journey time, the new China Eastern service has now overtaken Singapore Airlines' New York-Singapore flight, which lasts about 19 hours and previously held the title for the world's longest commercial service.

Dubai economy to expand by 4.5% next year

GROWTH TO BE DRIVEN BY TOURISM, RISING POPULATION AND SPENDING

DUBAI
BY NIVETHA DAYANAND
Assistant Business Editor

Dubai's economy is forecast to expand by 4.5 per cent in 2026, maintaining the same pace as 2025 and outperforming global growth trends, Emirates NBD said in its latest economic outlook. The expansion will be supported by ongoing strength across both the private and public sectors, continued recovery in tourism, infrastructure investment, and a steady increase in population and visitor numbers.

The projection underlines Dubai's strong economic fundamentals, with the bank estimating global GDP to average 3.1 per cent next year, while advanced economies are expected to grow by 1.6 per cent and emerging markets by 4.0 per cent.

Stronger growth

According to Emirates NBD, Dubai's economy expanded by an estimated 4.4 per cent in the first half of 2025, up from 3.3 per cent in 2023 and 3.2 per cent in 2024. Purchasing Managers' Index data for October and November rose to 54.5, its strongest reading since January.

The report highlighted that a softer monetary policy expected from the US Federal Reserve and reduced global trade uncertainty will provide additional support to the UAE economy next year.

15.7m

tourists visited Dubai between January and October, up 5%

Lower interest rates and improved financing conditions are also expected to boost investment activity, while easing geopolitical tensions in the region should reinforce investor and consumer confidence.

Tourism remains one of the main pillars of Dubai's growth story. Visitor numbers rose around 5 per cent in 2025, reaching 15.7 million between January and October, and the report sees further upside in 2026. Medical tourism has emerged as a further growth driver. This segment contributed to a 20 per cent year-on-year increase in GDP for human health and social work activities during the first half of 2025.

Dubai's rapid population growth continues to be a major factor behind its economic expansion. The emirate's population crossed the 4 million mark in 2025, representing a 5.4 per cent year-on-year increase, with official projections aiming for 5.8 million by 2040.

This demographic expansion is driving sustained demand for real estate, construction, education, health care, and utilities.

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